Anxiety and Related Disorders ✕

Today's goal • 3/3 items

Module 1
Learn With PsycLearn Essentials

Module 2
Introduction to Psychological Disorders

Module 3
Opening to Anxiety Disorders

Module 4
Components of Anxiety

Module 5
Disorders that Involve Anxiety Part 1

Generalized Anxiety Disorders
- ✓ Diagnostic Criteria, Prevalence, Contributing Factors, and Cultural Issues for Generalized Anxiety Disorder
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Check Your Understanding: Generalized Anxiety Disorder
  Practice Assignment • Grade: 100%

Panic Disorder
- ✓ Diagnostic Criteria, Prevalence, Contributing Factors, and Cultural Issues for Panic Disorder
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Check Your Understanding: Panic Disorder
  Practice Assignment • Grade: 80%

Specific Phobias
- ✓ Diagnostic Criteria and Prevalence for Specific Phobias
  Reading • 15 min
- ○ **Contributing Factors for Specific Phobias**
  Reading • 10 min
- ○ Classical Conditioning of Specific Phobias
  Video • 2 min
- ○ Operant Conditioning and Negative Reinforcement of Specific Phobias
  Video • 3 min
- ○ Cultural Issues for Specific Phobias
  Reading • 2 min
- ○ Check Your Understanding: Specific Phobias
  Practice Assignment • 6 min

Key Takeaways
- ○ Key Takeaways: Disorders that Involve Anxiety Part 1
  Reading • 10 min

Module 5 Quiz
- ○ Module Quiz: Disorders that Involve Anxiety Part 1
  Graded Assignment • 10 min

Module 6
Disorders that Involve Anxiety Part 2

Module 7
Conclusion

Module 8
Cumulative Quiz

Module 9
Course Resources

Module 10
PsycLearn Essentials APA Student Resources

Contributing Factors for Specific Phobias

0:04 / 8:33 1x

Biological Preparedness

As you have read, there are many different types of specific phobias, but the most commonly held ones tend to focus on objects or situations that could cause people harm or death. The frequency of phobias of spiders, snakes, and heights bears this out. However, absent from lists of common phobias is an object that also carries a degree of danger: firearms. This raises the question: Why is there a disconnect between different types of dangerous items?

Evolutionary theory suggests that millenia of exposure to death or disability from contact with snakes, spiders, and heights has biased humans toward fearing those stimuli (McNally, 2016; Seligman, 1971). Evolutionary psychologists assert that ancestral humans who developed fears of lethal animals and situations were more likely to survive and pass their genes onto future generations. This passing on of their genes led to the inherited trait of a bias toward fearing life threatening animals and situations. Martin Seligman coined the term **biological preparedness** to represent this simple idea—because of our species' evolutionary history, modern humans are more likely to learn to fear and develop phobias about objects and situations that were threats to our ancestors' lives. This provides a simple explanation for why people easily develop phobias about snakes (which today kill about five Americans per year; National Institute for Occupational Safety and Health, 2020), whereas phobias about guns (which kill 20 times that number of Americans every day; Centers for Disease Control, 2020) are virtually nonexistent.

Learning Theory

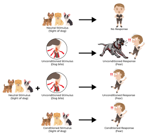
Phobias can be acquired through learned (also known as conditioned) associations. For example, direct experience with a traumatic event, such as Miguel being bitten by a swarm of spiders, can result in a specific phobia. Three different types of conditioning—classical conditioning, operant conditioning, and observational learning—play a role in the development and persistence of specific phobias.

Classical Conditioning

Classical conditioning is a powerful influence on thoughts, feelings, and behaviors because it occurs outside of conscious awareness. **Classical conditioning** occurs when an individual comes to associate two stimuli. The **neutral stimulus (NS)** does not elicit any response on its own. The **unconditioned stimulus (UCS)** produces an automatic response, one that does not require learning. This automatic response is called the **unconditioned response (UCR).** When a neutral stimulus (NS) is paired with an unconditioned stimulus (UCS), it starts to produce the same response as the unconditioned stimulus (UCS); this response is called the **conditioned response (CR).** The neutral stimulus (NS) then becomes known as the **conditioned stimulus (CS),** as it now produces a response because it is associated with the unconditioned stimulus (UCS).

To illustrate the way classical conditioning can produce a specific phobia, let us walk through how a fear of dogs can develop. According to classical conditioning, if a stimulus that we have no particular reaction to, (the neutral stimulus [NS]), becomes associated with something that naturally creates fear (the unconditioned stimulus [UCS]), it generates an unconditioned response (UCR). In this way, the neutral stimulus (NS) becomes associated with the unconditioned stimulus (UCS) and the person learns to fear it as well, resulting in a conditioned response (CR).

Classical Conditioning



Note. Many specific phobias are learned through classical conditioning, when a neutral stimulus becomes associated with an unconditioned stimulus. After classical conditioning, the neutral stimulus becomes the conditioned stimulus, and it then generates the conditioned response.

Pairing a dog (NS) with the fear created by the pain of a dog bite (UCS), will form an association between dogs and a painful bite so that encountering other dogs in the future may elicit the same fear response. According to classical conditioning, the NS (dogs) becomes a conditioned stimulus (CS) and produces a conditioned response (CR) or a fear of dogs) similar to that elicited by the unconditioned stimulus, a dog bite (UCS), without being bitten by a dog. Now seeing any dog evokes the same response as a dog bite from a specific dog. Once people have learned to fear dogs, a dog is no longer a neutral stimulus (NS) but a conditioned stimulus (CS), and the fear that comes from seeing dogs in the absence of being bitten, is a conditioned response (CR).

Operant Conditioning and the Role of Negative Reinforcement in Fear Learning

Many forms of classical conditioning require repeated pairings of the NS and the UCS, but fear learning is capable of creating an association after a single pairing. For example, a single dog bite that results in pain and fear is enough to create a conditioned fear association. Often, in the absence of new pairings of the UCS and CS, classically-conditioned responses weaken over time and the CS stops evoking the CR. Why, then, would a person with a dog phobia (who would avoid dogs whenever possible) continue to fear dogs if they never get bitten again?

The enduring nature of conditioned phobias can be explained by **operant conditioning,** a type of learning in which behavioral change occurs as a result of the consequences of behavior. This means that the person associates their behavior with its consequences, in a process called **reinforcement.** With one type of reinforcement, **negative reinforcement,** we are likely to repeat behaviors that allow us to avoid or escape from an unpleasant stimulus. If people are able to escape the fearful experience of seeing the phobic stimulus, their avoidance behavior is reinforced and they are likely to continue avoiding the stimulus. In the example of dog phobia, the person will continue to avoid dogs to avoid the feeling of fear. But because they never get the opportunity to have a pleasant interaction with a dog, their phobia persists.

Observational Learning

Other than direct experience with trauma, a fear response can also be acquired through **observational learning**. Observational learning is the acquisition of information, skills, or behavior through watching the performance of others, either directly or via such media as films and videos. The observational learning of a fear response can occur by observing another individual's distress when faced with a fear-inducing stimulus (Öst, 1991; Öst & Hugdahl, 1981). For example, seeing a parent enduring painful electric shocks can create a fear of that experience in a child even though they did not feel the pain firsthand (Marin et al., 2020). Applying this example to phobias, seeing a person nearly drown can create a water phobia even in the absence of having a personal experience with nearly drowning.

Vicarious learning of a fear response occurs when a fear is evoked without any exposure or experience (direct or indirect) to a fear-inducing stimulus. Rather, the fear response is acquired by hearing or reading about the fear-inducing stimulus—for example, a person may acquire a fear of flying by viewing media coverage of a plane crash.

Although it's unethical to create phobias in psychological research, researchers have used lesser degrees of fear to demonstrate vicarious fear learning (Olsson and Phelps, 2004; Szczepanik et al., 2020). For example, in one study, researchers had pairs of friends act as participants. One member of each pair received electric shocks while the other watched. Both participants in each pair realized that the shocks were only being delivered when a yellow square was being shown on a computer screen. Not surprisingly, this led to the friend who was getting shocked showing a physiological fear response whenever they saw the yellow square. Afterwards, the friend who had been observing was shown the same yellow square and physiological measures of fear were taken. Like their friends, observers showed physiological fear responses when they saw the yellow square. Though they had never been shocked, they had come to fear the square because they witnessed their friend's experience.

Mark as completed

Like Dislike Report an issue

Go to next item →